

and practically all of the INI files that carried configuration information. These were superseded by the Windows Registry.

Windows Registry location

So now that you know what the Windows Registry is all about, where can you find the registry? In newer versions of Windows, the %SystemRoot%\System32\Config\ folder contains the SAM, SECURITY, SOFTWARE, SYSTEM, and DEFAULT registry files, among others.

Registry data is stored as .DAT files in older versions of Windows under the %WINDIR% folder. The REG.DAT is the single registry file used by Windows 3.11 for the complete Windows Registry. Windows 2000 maintains a backup copy of the HKEY LOCAL MACHINE System key that it can utilise to troubleshoot an issue with the current one. Starting with Windows 10 version 1803, the operating system no longer backs up the registry into the RegBack folder. If you open the folder, you'll still see the individual files but they're all 0 kB in size. That means they're empty. Microsoft recommends that you use System Restore points instead.

The next chapter will go into the overall organisation of the registry. **d**